

## How it Grows

A glance at the colossal increase in the use of messaging services:

- There are 85 million corporate voice mail boxes currently in use, with the number expected to grow to 140 million by 2003 (Ovum Evaluates Unified Messaging, Ovum Ltd, 1997).
- There will be 170 million subscribers for unified messaging, provided by service providers by 2006 (Ovum Unified Messaging Report, Ovum Ltd, January 1999).
- The Kauffman Group estimates that fax pages over IP will exceed 250 billion worldwide by 2004.
- IDC estimates that almost seven million people used remote or wireless technologies to access e-mail for business purposes in 1996, and that the number will rise to 40 million by 2001 (IDC Mobile Messaging: A Comprehensive Analysis, 1997).
- Dataquest estimates that by 2001, between 27 per cent (low-end systems) and 50 per cent (high-end systems) for all voice mail systems will ship with unified messaging (Dataquest Messaging—Unified, Integrated, Universal, January 1998).

As a sender, you can avail of several options as to where to send a message. As a recipient of a message too, you do not have to necessarily use a PC or a telephone to access your messages. Whether you do it via fax, e-mail or voice mail, it doesn't make a dime of a difference. Like wireless before it, e-mail and the World Wide Web have been successful steps in the evolution of modes of communication, and UM is another step in that evolution.

### How does it work?

In UM, getting information through your telephone system entails receiving voice messages through voice protocols such as voice mail. If you are an e-mail user, you can contact someone who doesn't use an e-mail service, but does use voice mail, by sending a text message as an attachment. The attached message sent to a phone will be converted to voice using text-to-speech technology.

The receiver can reply, forward or delete the message without ever knowing whether the message was sent to him as a fax, voice or e-mail. You, in turn, receive your reply as a voice message attachment in your mailbox, which is easily converted to text using speech-to-text technology.

Besides, if you have just a single telephone line for working on the Internet and receiving incoming calls, you need not worry about losing your calls during Internet sessions anymore.

With the Unified Messaging System (UMS), all you need to do is log on to a voice mailbox online and check for messages. This can be done either through a visual interface such as Microsoft's Outlook Express or through an e-mail client that supports UMS. The sender of the message and the length of the calls can be recorded while making use of the e-mail client.

You can also locate the sender of the messages and the length of the calls. If you wish to listen to messages on your PC, it can be done by enabling the text-to-speech application.

If you are a wireless user, you can avail of this service on your mobile handset wherein the different voice mails, e-mail and fax messages are collected as voice mail, and you can access your messages by using the soft keys of your handset and selecting the message. The text-to-fax technology is all about directing e-mail to your fax machine.

Some popular and efficient packages such as Microsoft Outlook at the front-end and Microsoft Exchange as its back-end, offer facilities to categorise messages and maintain them along with your contact lists.

Even the caller's telephone numbers can be stored in the subject of the messages, letting you avail of the facilities that would automatically render journal entries and send messages to a different folder. Similarly, fax-mails and fax-on-demand features are in-built in them and can be integrated easily. As you can see, it is the first step towards global connectivity.

Infographics: Jaya Shetty

